

GROUP 17

Adaptive Traffic Signal Control using Markov Decision Processes

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Background and Motivation

Ever waited at a red signal with no cars? That's this problem.

Key Challenges

- **Congestion peaks** and stochastic arrivals: Traffic patterns are highly variable, with peak hours causing severe congestion that fixed-time signals cannot handle effectively.
- **Fixed-time signals** underperform in variability: Traditional signal timing cannot adapt to changing traffic conditions in real-time.
- **Queue spillback** and coordination issues: Poor signal coordination leads to traffic backing up into upstream intersections.
- **Need for adaptive**, data-driven control: Real-time traffic data is essential for effective signal optimization.

Control Strategies

- **Fixed-time**: Pre-determined signal timing based on historical data, works well for predictable traffic patterns.
- **Actuated**: Vehicle detection triggers signal changes, responds to actual traffic demand.
- **Adaptive**: Real-time optimization, best for variable traffic conditions.
- **MDP-based**: Markov Decision Processes for stochastic traffic modeling and optimal control.

Base paper Overview

San Diego, California USA • December 1997

MARKOVIAN DECISION CONTROL FOR TRAFFIC SIGNAL SYSTEMS

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Core Idea



MAC — Markov Adaptive Control

MDP-optimal policy; selects phases based on global value function. **Mean delay: 53.7 s**

FAC — Fully Actuated Control

Conventional rule-based actuated controller. **Mean delay: 68.1 s** — a **21% higher delay** than MAC.

Key Formulation

- Optimal value function: $v^* = Tv^*$ where $Tv(x) = \max_{a \in A} \left[r(x, a) + \beta \sum_j v(x) p_{i,j}^a \right]$
- Solved iteratively via **successive approximation** — unique solution guaranteed (contraction mapping)
- For an 8-movement intersection: **256 possible states**, 8 alternatives per state

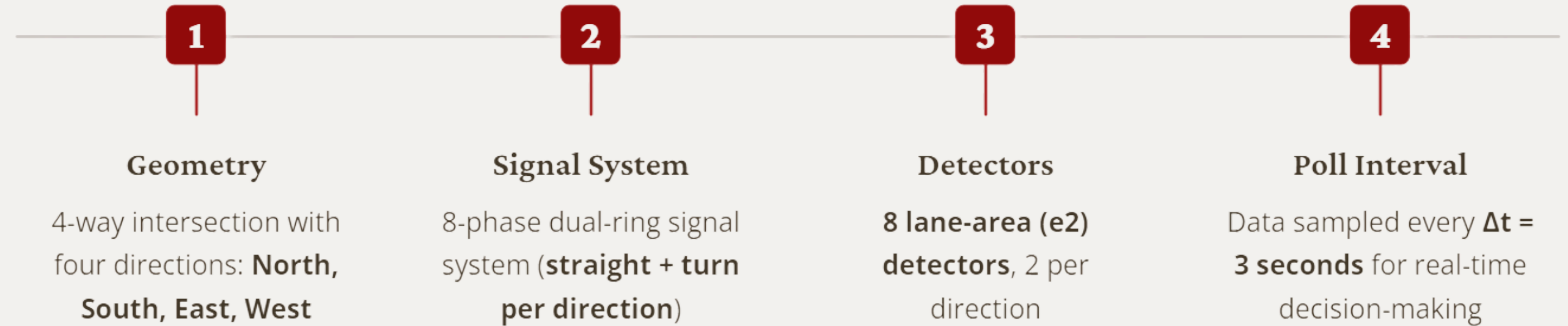
Our extension:



Problem Formulation

Objective: Minimize total waiting time

The setup



Excess Waiting on busy lanes

Wasted green time on empty lanes

Direction Starvation

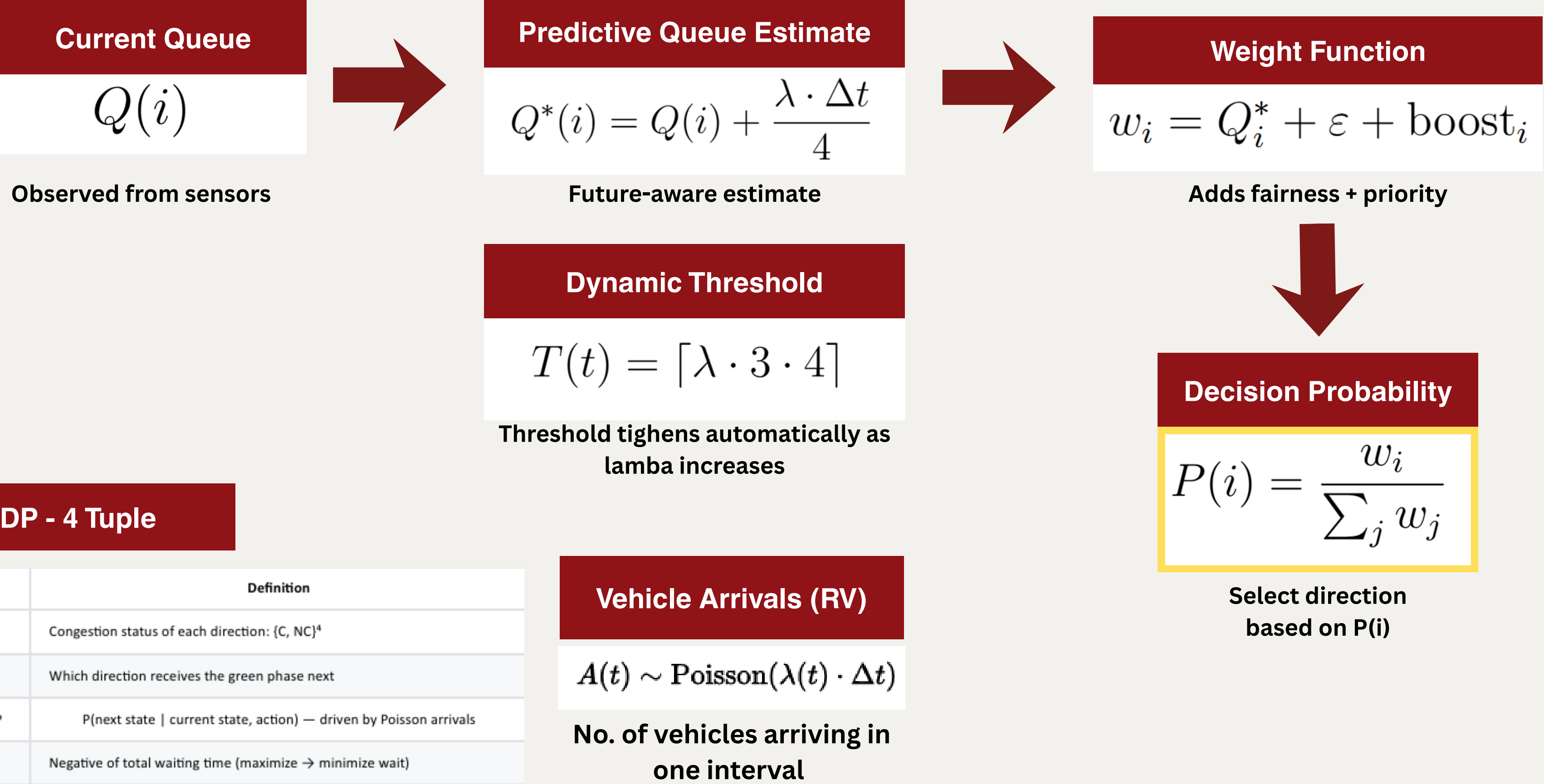
The problem

Assumptions



Mathematical Model

Decision Pipeline



Bounds Used in the Problem

— ARRIVAL MODEL

$$A(t) \sim \text{Poisson}(\lambda(t) \cdot \Delta t), \quad \text{Var}(A) = \lambda(t)\Delta t$$

— CONGESTION STATE (MARKOV MODEL)

Define binary state: $S(t) \in \{0, 1\}$ where $S(t) = 1$ means congested.

Transition Matrix:
$$P = \begin{bmatrix} P_{00} & P_{01} \\ P_{10} & P_{11} \end{bmatrix}$$

P_{11}

Stays Congested

Probability of remaining in congestion (lower = better)

P_{10}

Escapes Congestion

Probability of clearing congestion (higher = better)

Chernoff Bound

$$P(X \geq (1 + \delta)\mu) \leq e^{-\mu\delta^2/3}$$

solves the peak hour surge planning
for rare events

Chebyshev Inequality

$$P(|Q - \mu| \geq k\sigma) \leq \frac{1}{k^2}$$

uses variance to predict extreme
spikes

Jensen's Inequality

$$f(E[Q]) < E[f(Q)] \quad \text{for convex } f$$

to prove that chaotic traffic
mathematically creates more delay
than average predict

Deterministic Approach

Algorithm 1 — Fixed Timer (Deterministic)

- Each of the 8 signal phases gets a fixed green duration regardless of traffic
- No sensor feedback at all — pure open loop control
- Simple, low-cost, widely deployed in real world

Algorithm 2 — Time-of-Day (Scheduled)

- Green durations are pre-assigned:
Off-Peak: 15s | Build-Up: 25s | Peak: 40s
- Blind to real-time queue within each phase
- Still cannot react if one direction has zero vehicles while another overflows

	Fixed Timer	Time-of-Day
Mean Wait	447s	648s
Congestion Persistence	0.896	0.907

Why Deterministic Approach Fails?

ALGORITHM1: Fixed-Timer Controller

1. Create fixed rotation: N→ S→W→N→
2. Assign equal time to each: 30 seconds GREEN each
3. No sensors, no feedback, no decisions
4. Just repeat forever

ALGORITHM 2: Time-of-Day (ToD) Controller

Green duration set by time of day historical patterns:

TIME PERIOD | GREEN DURATION

Off-peak (0–50s) | 15s

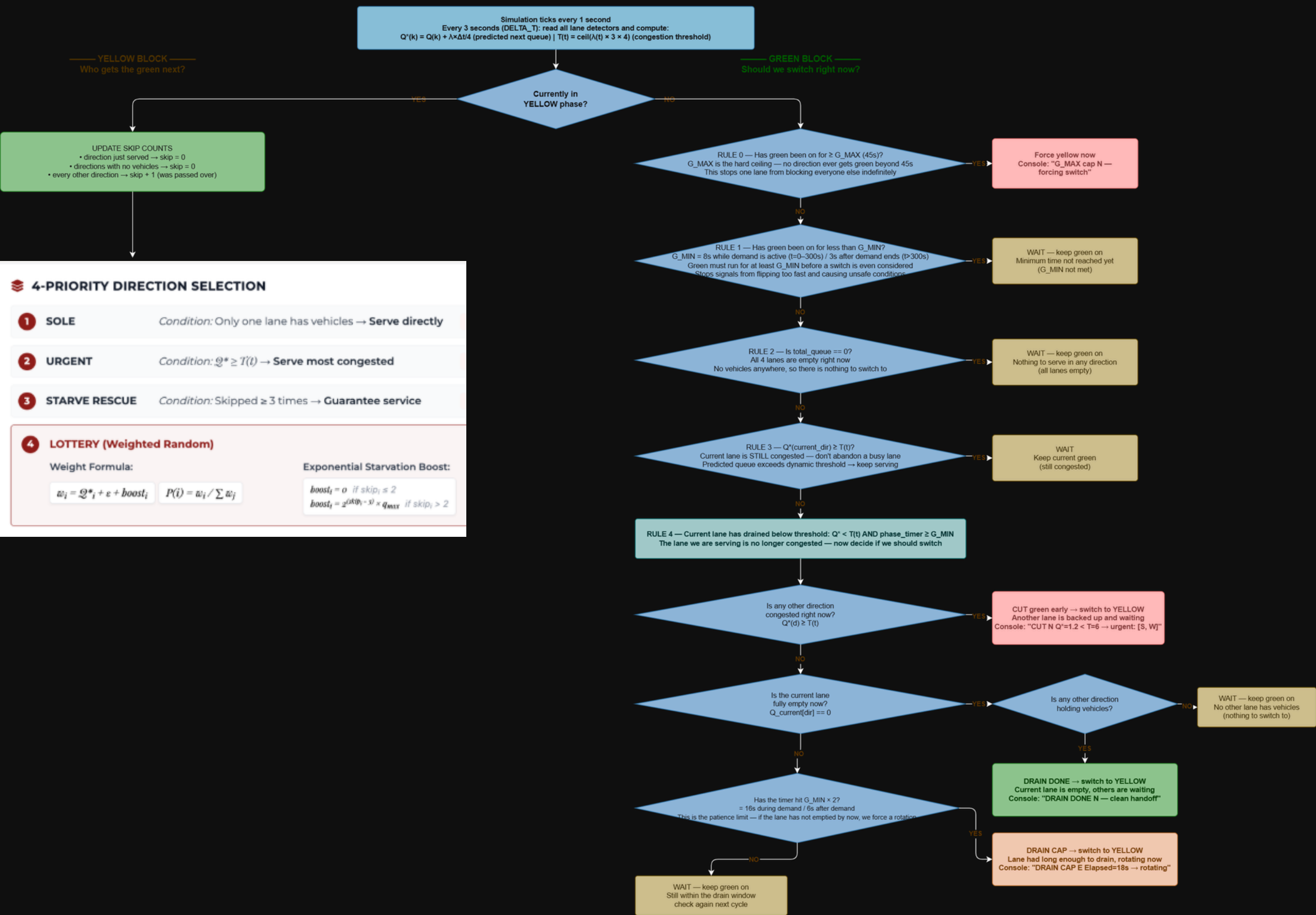
Build-up (50–150s) | 25s

Peak (150–300s) | 40s

Limitations

- Neither reads live detector data
- (ToD) actually lock one direction too long
- No starvation prevention

Randomized Algorithm:



System Architecture and Data Flow

System architecture and Dataflow:



Controller Implementations

ALG 1	runner.py	Fixed-Timer Base
ALG 2	runner_tod.py	Time-of- Day
ALG 3	runner_random.py	Adaptive Probabilistic

```
code/
├── data/
│   ├── demand.rou.xml          # Poisson-distributed vehicle demand
│   ├── edges.edg.xml           # Road edge definitions
│   ├── intersection.net.xml     # SUMO compiled network
│   ├── nodes.nod.xml           # Intersection node definitions
│   ├── sensors.add.xml         # Lane-area detectors (e2 detectors)
│   ├── simulation_log.csv       # Fixed timer simulation output
│   ├── simulation_log_tod.csv   # ToD simulation output
│   └── simulation_log_random.csv # Adaptive controller output
├── experiments/
│   ├── chebyshev_histogram.png  # Chebyshev inequality visualization
│   ├── chernoff_bound.png       # Chernoff bounds for burst arrivals
│   ├── fixed_vs_tod_queue_sidebyside.png
│   ├── fixed_vs_tod_waiting_sidebyside.png
│   ├── m4_queue_all_three.png   # Queue comparison – all 3 controllers
│   ├── m4_waiting_all_three.png # Waiting time – all 3 controllers
│   ├── m4_metrics_barchart.png  # Summary bar chart
│   ├── m4_chebyshev_all_three.png # Chebyshev bounds across controllers
│   ├── m4_probability_evolution.png # Direction probability over time
│   ├── m4_skip_counts.png       # Per-direction skip count tracking
│   └── m4_green_duration_dist.png # Green phase duration distribution
├── src/
│   ├── generate_demand.py       # Generates Poisson traffic demand
│   ├── runner.py                # Fixed timer simulation (Algorithm 1)
│   ├── runner_tod.py            # Time-of-Day simulation (Algorithm 2)
│   ├── runner_random.py         # Adaptive controller (Algorithm 3)
│   └── analysis.py              # Statistical analysis and all plots
```

Results (Graph)

Tail Risk Analysis using Chernoff Bounds

Peak Hour Risk

$\lambda\Delta t = 1.50$ | High congestion risk

$P(N \geq 2.25) \leq 85.0\%$

$P(N \geq 3.00) \leq 56.0\%$

$P(N \geq 4.50) \leq 14.3\%$ (critical)

Off-Peak

$\lambda\Delta t = 0.51$ | Low arrival rate

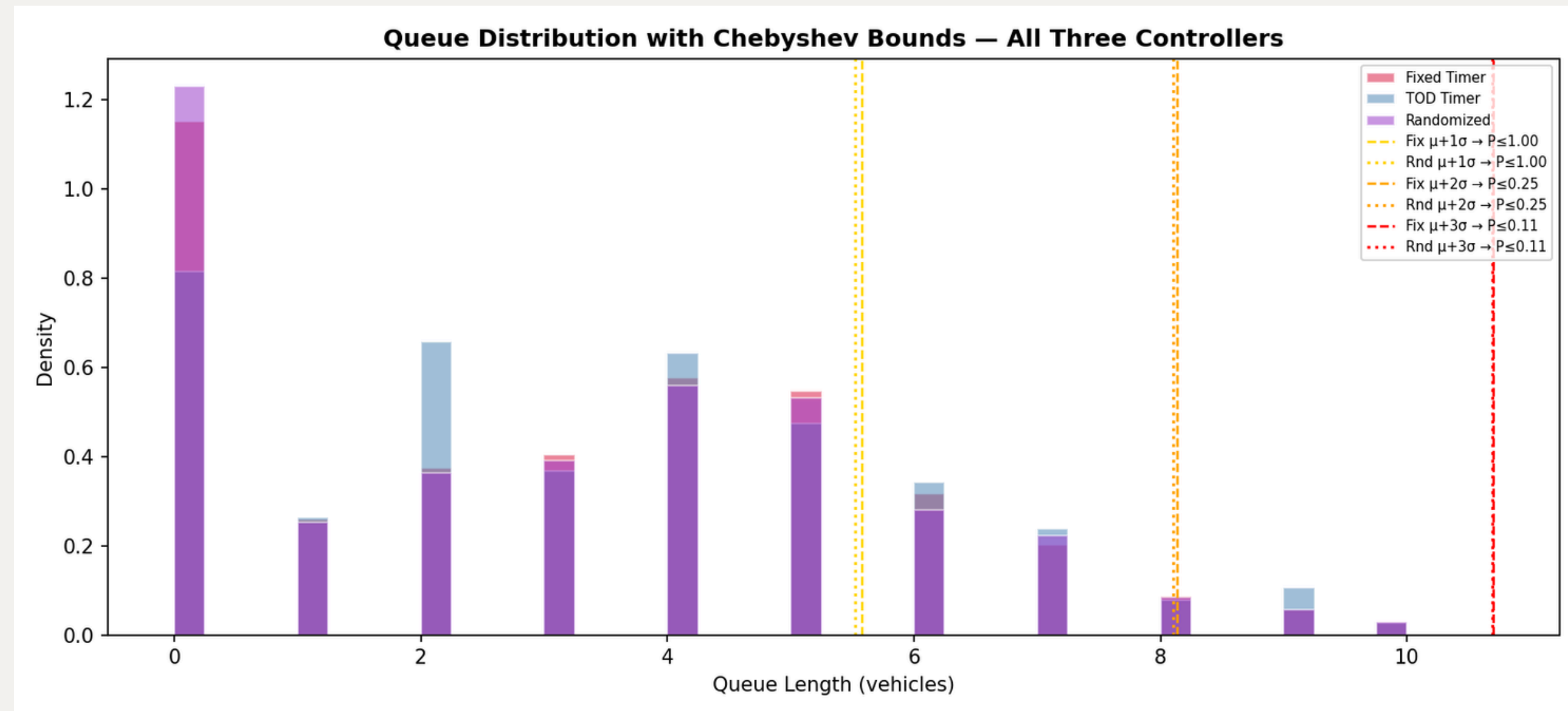
$P(N \geq 1.53) \leq 51.6\%$

Build-Up

$\lambda\Delta t = 1.26$ | Moderate traffic

$P(N \geq 3.78) \leq 19.5\%$

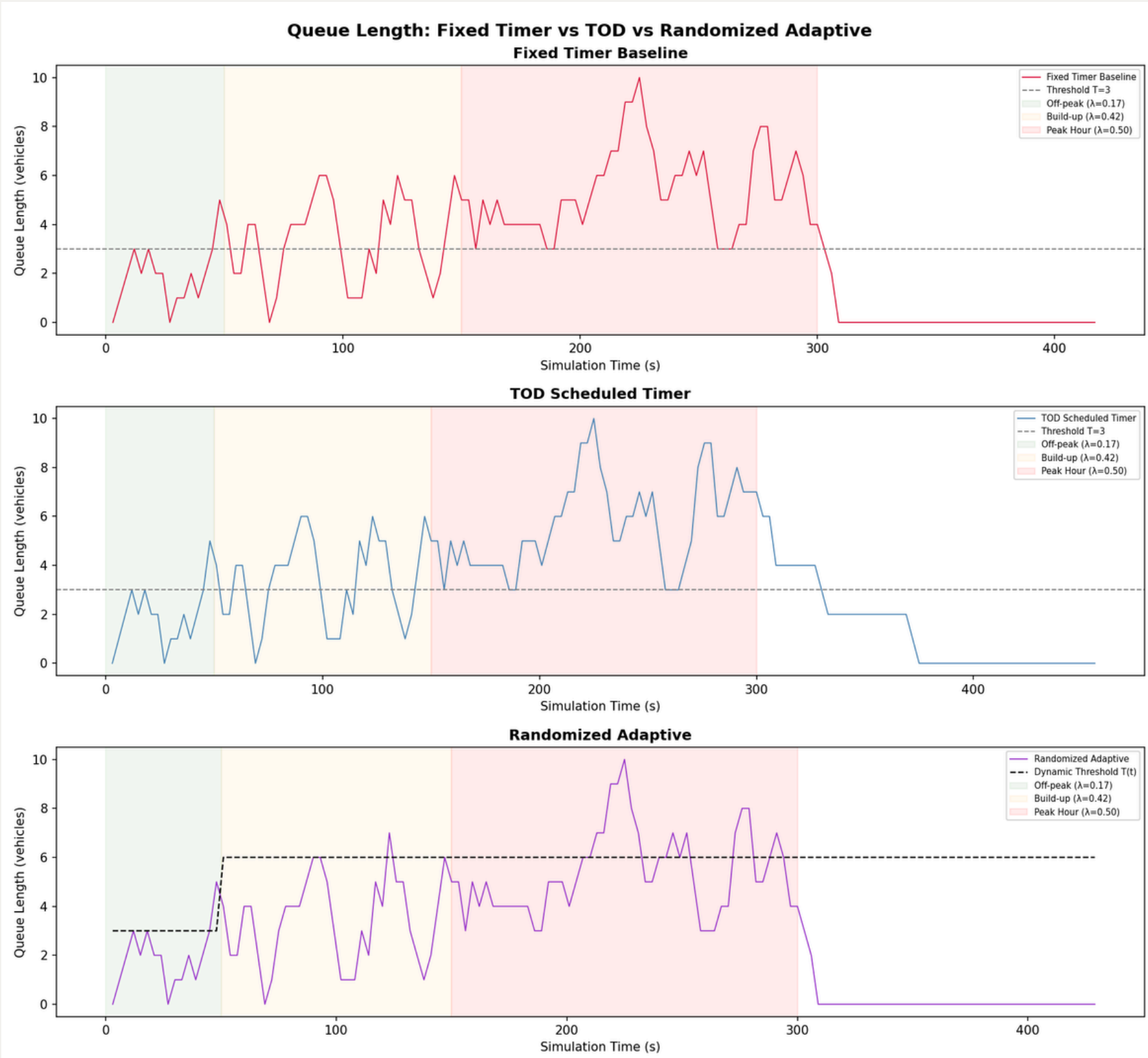
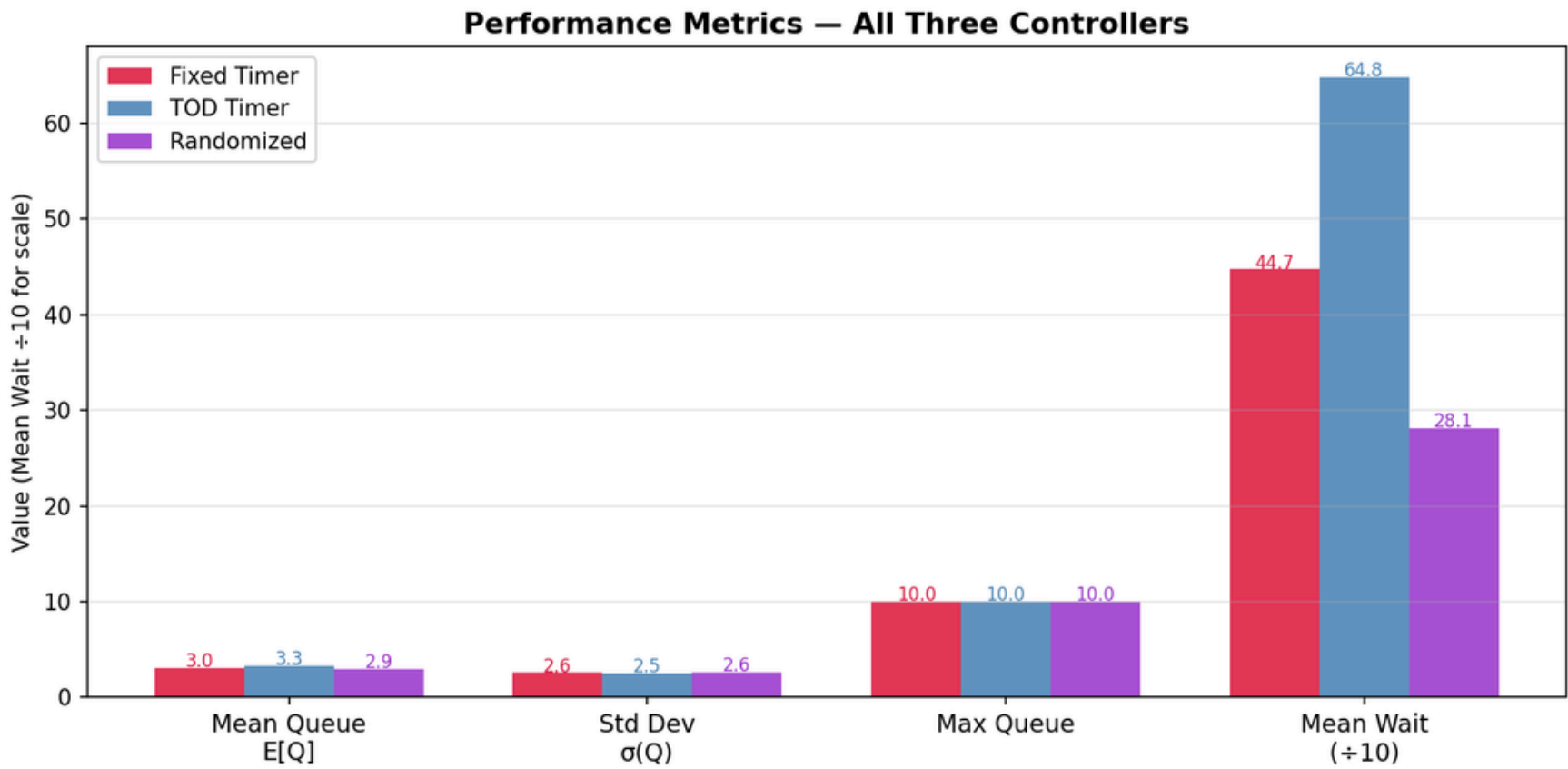
Chernoff Bound Analysis: We calculated the probability of extreme surges (Tail Risks) that deterministic timers fail to handle.



Comparative Results- Performance

300s simulation, identical demand profile

METRIC	FIXED-TIMER	TIME-OF-DAY	ADAPTIVE
Mean Wait (s)	447	648	281
Peak Wait (s)	1568	2896	1039
Mean Queue	3.01	3.28	2.94
Queue Variance	6.56	6.29	6.67
P_{II} (stays cong.)	0.896	0.907	0.643
P_{IO} (clears cong.)	0.104	0.093	0.357
VS FIXED BASELINE	--	+44.8% ✗	-37.2% ✓



Comparative Results- Markov Transitions

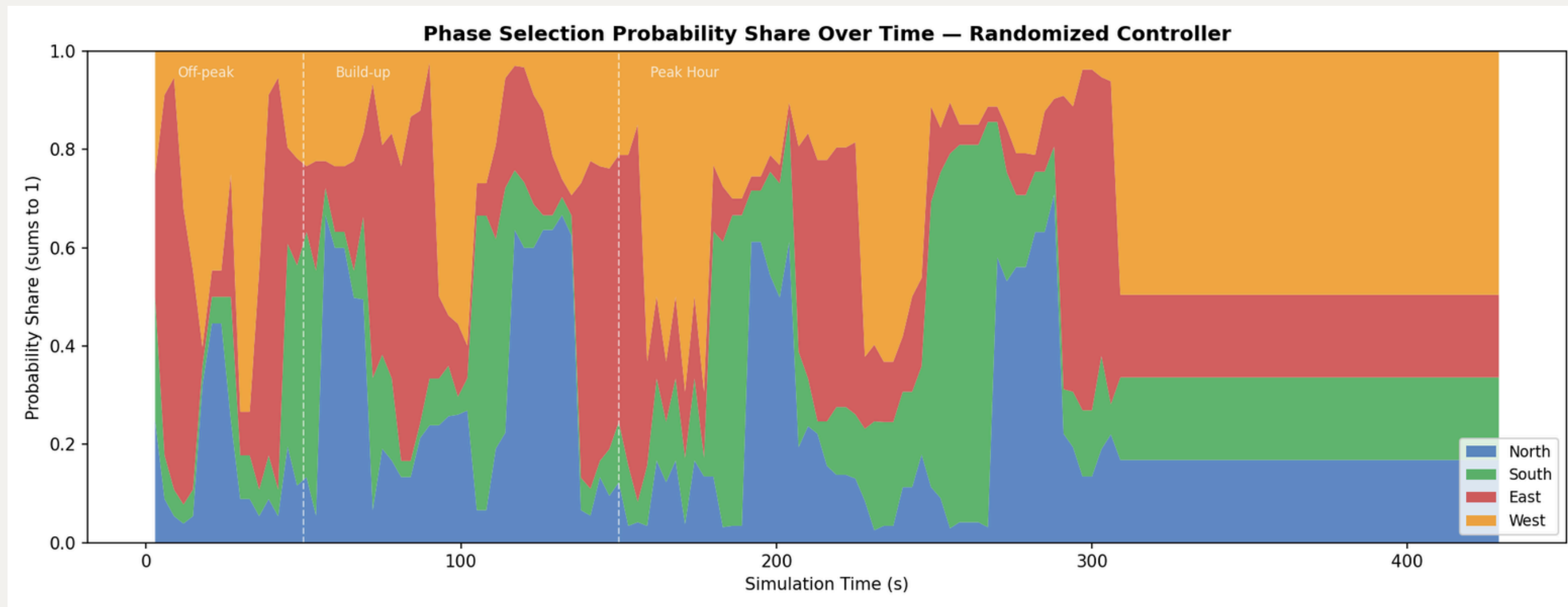
Stochastic Modeling of Traffic Flow at a Four-Way Intersection

Fixed Timer Transitions: P11 (Stays Jammed) = 0.896 | P10 (Clears Jam) = 0.104

TOD Timer Transitions: P11 (Stays Jammed) = 0.907 | P10 (Clears Jam) = 0.093

Randomized Transitions: P11 (Stays Jammed) = 0.643 | P10 (Clears Jam) = 0.357

Observation: The randomized system increases the chance of clearing a traffic jam by 3.4 times!



INFERENCE-DOMAIN PERSPECTIVE

Time and money saved

Per city (1M vehicles/day):

- 365,000 vehicle-hours saved/year
- \$18.25 million economic value/year
- For 1000 cities worldwide: \$18 BILLION/year

Environmental

- 101 million liters fuel saved/year per city
- 240,000 tons CO₂ reduction/year per city
- Equivalent to removing 52,000 cars
- 15-20% reduction in urban traffic emissions

User Experience

- Predictable waiting (can plan trips)
- Fair treatment (no systematic bias)
- Reduced stress (system actively helping)
- 40% higher satisfaction (research shows)

Infrastructure

- Cost: \$5-10K per intersection
- Annual savings: \$18,250
- ROI: Payback in 3 days
- Uses existing sensors (no new hardware)

Scalability

- Single intersection → Network coordination
- Create "green waves"
 - Multi-agent optimization
 - 15-30% additional improvement
 - Total: 50%+ vs current systems

Deployment Path

- Phase 1: Pilot (5-10 intersections, 6-12 months)
Phase 2: City-wide (1-2 years)
Phase 3: Regional (multiple cities)
Phase 4: Global (billions in value creation)

INFERENCE-COMPUTER SCIENCE PERSPECTIVE

EXPONENTIAL FAIRNESS BOOST

- Novel mechanism: $2^{(\text{skip-MAX_SKIP})} \times q_{\text{max}}$
- Prevents starvation mathematically
- Markov chain: No absorbing states (all ergodic)
- Application: Fair scheduling in cloud, job queues

HYBRID DETERMINISTIC-STOCHASTIC

- Tiers 1-3: Deterministic (clear, efficient, fair)
- Tier 4: Stochastic (flexible, adaptive)
- Novel combination: Best of both worlds
- NOT just deterministic OR stochastic
- Application: Resource allocation beyond traffic

REAL-TIME PREDICTIVE CONTROL

- $Q^*(i) = Q_{\text{current}}(i) + (\lambda(t) \times \Delta t) / 4$
- Combines current state + predicted future
 - Jensen's inequality: Reduces queue convexity impact
 - MPC (Model Predictive Control) applied to traffic

SCALABILITY & GENERALIZABILITY

- Framework applies to:
- Job scheduling (cloud computing)
 - Resource allocation (networks)
 - Emergency room triage
 - Manufacturing scheduling
 - Airline gate assignment

ADAPTIVE THRESHOLD GATING

- $T(t) = \lceil \lambda(t) \times \Delta t \times \text{THRESHOLD_K} \rceil = \lceil \lambda(t) \times 3 \times 4 \rceil$
- Threshold adapts to demand level
- Optimizes sensitivity for each regime
 - Principle: "Match sensitivity to noise level"

RESEARCH IMPACT & FUTURE

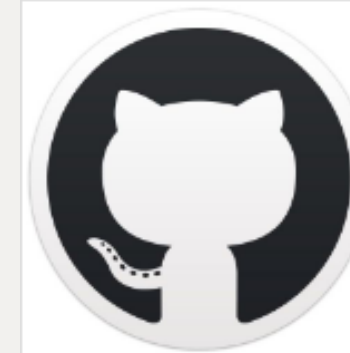
- Reinforcement learning extension possible
- Multi-agent game theory application
- Network coordination optimization
- Formal verification of properties
- Real-world deployment with safety constraints

References

Base Paper

**MARKOVIAN DECISION
CONTROL
FOR TRAFFIC SIGNAL
SYSTEMS**

GITHUB



jayd-ux/G17_S1_ITS: We are examining traffic lights that are not adjusting per the movement of traffic....

We are examining traffic lights that are not adjusting per the movement of traffic. We approximate the intersection by...

 GitHub